

DEVELOPING MESSENGERS — THE WEEKLY 1:1

A guide for leaders investing in their team

"Great 1:1s don't just happen — they're built."

PRIMARY OBJECTIVES

PROFESSIONAL &
PERSONAL DEVELOPMENT

ALIGNMENT WITH
MISSION & DIRECTION

HONEST, DIRECT,
MEANINGFUL
COMMUNICATION

STANDARDS

WEEKLY & CONSISTENT

20-60 Minutes

Don't cancel

Protect the meeting.
Canceling signals your
team member isn't a
priority.

Start on time

Respect their time.
Consistency builds trust
and sets the tone.

Be fully present

Phone away. Laptop
closed. This time belongs
to them.

WHO BRINGS WHAT

LEADER

Sets the context for the meeting

- Team and department objectives, goals, and outcomes
- Vision, direction, and organizational identity
- Current priorities and what matters most right now
- Deliberate alignment of each member's skills, giftings, and role

TEAM MEMBER

Owns and drives the agenda

- A prepared agenda with specific topics
- An honest account of priorities and progress
- Challenges, obstacles, and open feedback
- Humility and a willingness to act on what's discussed

ESSENTIAL SKILLS FOR LEADERS

Communication

Listen well, ask great questions, give and receive feedback with care.

Follow-through

Hold accountability for performance, results, and commitments made.

Coaching

Develop team members to develop themselves — invest in Messengers.

WHEN DONE WELL, THE 1:1 PRODUCES...

- High connection to mission and people
- High alignment with organizational direction
- High clarity and focus day-to-day
- High individual performance and contribution
- High candor, transparency, and trust
- Team members growing into their potential

ENVIRONMENT

The 1:1 must be a **safe, open, high-trust** space — and that is the leader's responsibility to create. Growth happens when team members are challenged with objectives that mature, advance, and increase their skills. Leaders show up prepared, present, and committed to honoring the person in front of them.

1:1 DIAGNOSTICS — WHEN SOMETHING'S OFF

Identify the symptom. Apply the solution.

If the meeting isn't working, something intentional needs to change.

PREPARATION & STRUCTURE

SYMPTOM

The team member comes with nothing to discuss. Meetings feel aimless or awkward.



SOLUTION

Clarify ownership: the team member brings the agenda. Send a simple prompt before the meeting — "Come ready with your top 3 priorities and one challenge."

SYMPTOM

Every meeting covers the same topics with no forward movement.



SOLUTION

End each meeting by naming one specific action item per person. Open the next meeting by reviewing what was committed to. Progress requires accountability.

SYMPTOM

The leader does most of the talking. The team member is passive.



SOLUTION

Ask more, tell less. Replace statements with questions: "What do you think the next step is?" The goal is development, not direction.

TRUST & ENVIRONMENT

SYMPTOM

The team member only shares good news. Challenges or failures never surface.



SOLUTION

Model vulnerability first. Share something you're working through as a leader. Safety is built by the leader, not assumed. Ask directly: "What's the hardest thing on your plate right now?"

SYMPTOM

The team member seems disengaged or gives short, surface-level answers.



SOLUTION

Start with the person before the work. Ask about energy, bandwidth, or what's been heavy lately. Connection precedes performance.

CONSISTENCY & COMMITMENT

SYMPTOM

Meetings are frequently rescheduled, shortened, or skipped.



SOLUTION

Treat the 1:1 as non-negotiable. Canceling communicates that the team member is a low priority. Protect it on both calendars — recurring, same time, every week.

SYMPTOM

Commitments made in the meeting are forgotten by the next one.



SOLUTION

Take brief notes during every meeting. Track action items in Asana. Follow-through is a leadership skill — it signals that what was said actually mattered.

SYMPTOM

The team member doesn't seem to be growing. Work is competent but flat.



SOLUTION

Ask where they want to grow, then connect it to a real challenge or project. Development requires a destination. Help them name it, then build toward it together.

SYMPTOM

The team member seems unclear on how their work connects to the mission.



SOLUTION

Regularly bring the "why" back into the conversation. Name how their specific work contributes to the mission. Alignment isn't a one-time conversation — it's a recurring one.

A note on diagnostics: If multiple symptoms are present at once, start with trust and environment. Almost every other problem in a 1:1 is downstream of a leader who hasn't yet created a safe space for honest conversation. Fix the foundation first.